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-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You
Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or
indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.
There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing
of other topics in the main exam.

PETE HEGSETH IN SINGAPORE

‘No China hegemony,
India critical anchor,
helps maintain
balance of power’



US Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth at Shangri-La Dialogue in Singapore, Saturday. AP

Flags Javelin co-production with India,
urges Asian allies to up defence spend

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, May 30

IN AN expansive articulation of American strategic intent in the Indo-Pacific, US Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth Saturday described India as a “critical anchor” to “hold the line” in South Asia and that a “powerful” India, acting in its own self-interest, “advances our shared goal of maintaining a balance of power across the region.”

Speaking at the Shangri La Dialogue in Singapore Saturday, he framed the balance of power in Asia as one “in which no state, including China, can impose its hegemony and hold the security or prosperity of our nation and our allies in question.”

At the same time, though, he struck a softer note on Beijing saying Washington was not seeking confrontation despite concerns over China’s military build-up. And that under US President Donald Trump, US-China relations were “better than they’ve been in years.”

Hegseth noted India’s

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POLITICS

INDIA SIGNS DEAL
WITH VIETNAM
FOR BRAHMOS
MISSILES

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EXPLAINED

The balancing act

Hegseth framing of India as an Indian Ocean anchor and defence co-production partner may be a bid to reassure Delhi that its engagement with Beijing does not come at India’s expense. At the same time, he flagged a Pacific dominated by any hegemon (read China) would “undermine the equilibrium we all seek to preserve.”

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Hegseth

modernisation of its military to bear its share of the security burden, particularly in the Indian Ocean, and praised its efforts to build “heavy industrial and logistics capacity to sustain high-end military operations, including the ability to repair and maintain shared platforms and support US Navy vessels operating forward in the theatre.”

The Defence Secretary announced that the US had committed to pursuing “co-production” of Javelin anti-tank guided munitions with India — “real, tangible steps to improve the collective readiness of our forces.” Defence co-production of this kind, with a sophisticated frontline weapon system, is framed as deepening the bilateral defence relationship.

“This kind of industrial muscle isn’t just a long-term

goal; it’s an immediate operational imperative, and the United States Department of War is leading the way,” he said.

Highlighting that Washington’s broader Indo-Pacific strategy was aimed at preserving regional stability while ensuring that no single power could dominate the region, he said: “What we seek ... is a genuinely stable equilibrium that works for Americans as well as for our allies.”

He added that the Indo-Pacific remained central to US security and prosperity, underlining that Washington remained committed to the region despite security challenges elsewhere, including in West Asia.

He further said that the era of the United States subsidising the defence of wealthy nations is over. “We need partners, not protectorates. We seek alliances built on shared responsibility, not dependency,” he said.

The US would continue to strengthen military capabilities and cooperation with allies to preserve regional stability, he said, adding that defence commitments have been undertaken by several Indo-Pacific partners, including India, Japan, South Korea, Australia, Singapore, Malaysia, Thailand, Vietnam and the Philippines.

In an echo of what Washington has been saying to European allies, Hegseth urged the Asian ones to increase their military spending to counter China’s power and dominance in the region, adding that a stronger, more self-reliant network of allies is essential to prevent aggression while preserving the balance of power.

“There is rightful alarm regarding China’s historic military buildup and the expansion of its military activities in the region and beyond,” he said, adding: “A Pacific dominated by any hegemon would unravel the re-

gional balance of power.”

“No state, including China, can impose its hegemony and hold the security or prosperity of our nation and our allies in question.”

“Less Shangri-La, more ships, more subs,” Hegseth said, underlining that the region needs to invest in defence capability more than conferences.

Responding to a question on India’s recent test of an advanced version of the Agni missile,

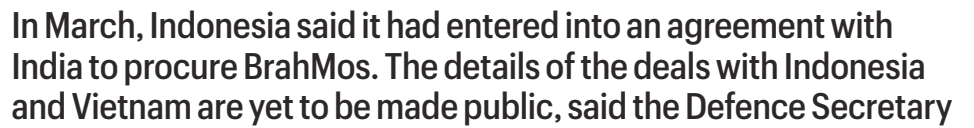
Hegseth said “both sides there are going to see understandable threats coming from the other...but we are not pointing a finger, at least from our view right now, at either country.”

He repeated President Donald Trump’s claims regarding the India-Pakistan ceasefire last year giving him credit for “brokering a peace between India and Pakistan, two nuclear-capable countries.”

'India has signed deal with Vietnam for supply of BrahMos'

New Delhi, May 30

He said India has a strong commitment to the ASEAN nations, adding: "...we treat all of you as 'friendly foreign coun-



He said India had undertaken major reforms in defence

"Our objective is not to create exclusive blocs, but inclusive and reliable partnerships that strengthen collective security and reduce strategic vulnerabilities," he said.

‘CAN’T PLEAD HELPLESSNESS’, SAYS TOP COURT

Why Supreme Court is cracking the whip against states over Chambal

Jay Mazoomdaar
New Delhi, May 30

THE SUPREME Court’s latest indictment of Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh over illegal sand mining in and around the inter-state National Chambal Gharial Sanctuary reflects years of judicial frustration with persistent administrative apathy, leading to an environmental and governance crisis.

The apex court, which took suo motu cognizance of the matter in March, was particularly harsh on Rajasthan in its May 26 order, slamming its “wholly casual, indifferent and indolent” conduct, and rebuking the state administration for demonstrating “persistent inaction” and a “disturbing lack of seriousness”.

Sand mining was prohibited in the Chambal sanctuary in 2006 but illegal extraction has continued and flourished over the years under organised syndicates. The indiscriminate sand extraction has severely disrupted the Chambal’s riverine ecosystem, damaging aquatic habitats and threatening environmental flows, putting at risk the survival of endangered gharials, freshwater dolphins and turtles.

In 2012, an IPS officer was crushed to death by a tractor carrying illegally mined sand in Morena, Madhya Pradesh. The Court’s May 26 order referred to the killing of two forest guards this year alone – one again in Morena last month, and another in Dholpur, Rajasthan, this January – to emphasize what it called a “serious erosion of the rule of law” in the region.

At a hearing on May 14, the Supreme Court expressed con-

Despite many dams and threat of sand mining, Chambal has highest conservation value among Gangetic rivers



Chambal’s aquatic ecosystem and forest landscape support more than 550 species. It also hosts the largest contiguous and most viable breeding populations of the critically endangered gharial. GETTY IMAGES

cern that authorities appeared to prosecute only vehicle drivers, while failing to investigate the financiers, contractors, operators and masterminds controlling illegal mining syndicates. “Such a lackadaisical pattern of investigation... raises serious concerns regarding... possible connivance at various levels of the administrative and enforcement machinery.” The Court stressed that environmental governance could not remain dependent on repeated judicial intervention and authorities must ensure “sustained and proactive enforcement” to curb illegal mining in the Chambal sanctuary landscape.

On forest personnel allegedly lacking adequate weapons to counter heavily armed mining mafias, the Court said: “The State cannot be permitted to plead helplessness.”

However, helplessness is what Madhya Pradesh effectively cited as long back as December 2021, when it proposed

opening 292 hectares for mining across five stretches of the Chambal and its tributary Parvati rivers.

The state argued that allowing regulated mining would free the Forest Department from devoting too much time, resources and efforts to fighting illegal extraction inside the sanctuary.

In 2022, the National Green Tribunal (NGT) accepted the findings of a committee constituted to prepare an action plan for the Chambal sanctuary that “mafias are using interior routes for conducting illegal mining in the national park, which are supported by political persons and are well equipped with weapons”.

In January 2023, Madhya Pradesh went ahead and denotified 207 hectares of the Chambal sanctuary. But, it failed to justify the decision before the NGT and had to withdraw it in February 2025.

Similarly, Rajasthan denotified 732 hectares of the Cham-

bal sanctuary in December 2025 to facilitate mining and urbanisation projects. The Supreme Court stayed the notification last month.

Chambal’s importance

Because of dark, foreboding myths around the Chambal – from a story linking its origins to a mountain of dripping leather, to the belief that Draupadi cursed its waters – the river, by all means mightier than the Yamuna, has remained one of India’s most pristine. No great cities or shrines came up on its banks, with the isolation later fostering the badland reputation of the Chambal ravines as a place where all manner of black sheep – rebel tribesmen and later bandits – found refuge.

The Chambal’s splendid isolation started to wane after people living in the arid districts of Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh started moving into the region. By 1960, the first dam on the Chambal – Gandhi Sagar –

was built on the Rajasthan-Madhya Pradesh border. In the next five decades, six major irrigation projects – Rana Pratap Sagar, Jawahar Sagar and Kota barrage, Parbati Pick-up Weir, Harish Chander Sagar and Gudha dam – 12 medium, 134 minor and several panchayat-level projects came up in the Chambal basin. There are many more in the pipeline while work continues on several dozen. Sand mining is an additional challenge. Since there is still no technology to use desert sand for construction, the pressure is entirely on riverbanks, reservoirs, and coasts.

According to a rough estimate published in its Sand Mining Framework in 2018, the Ministry of Mines put India’s sand demand at around 700 million tonnes in financial year 2016-17, growing at 6-7% annually. For supply, the framework reported 229 million tonnes of river sand production and another 22 million tonnes manufactured from coal-mine overburden.

Production data from four major sand-producing states – Uttarakhand, Maharashtra, Andhra Pradesh and Punjab – was not included in the 2018 framework. Even so, a supply gap of at least 40% underlines the scope for illegal mining.

However, sand is still the best insurance against coastal and riverbank erosion. And despite the threats to it, the Chambal still has the highest conservation value among rivers in the greater Gangetic basin.

Chambal is a vital corridor for dispersal of wildlife in an otherwise fragmented forest landscape across more than a dozen national parks and sanctuaries, such as Ranthambore, Keladevi, Kuno-Palpur, Madhav and Darrah-Mukundra.

● BUDDHA’S SACRED RELICS WERE DISPLAYED IN LADAKH IN 1950 TO BOOST THE MORALE AFTER THE INDO-PAK WAR OF 1947-48

In travels of Buddha’s sacred relics, India’s soft power outreach

Upasika Singhal
New Delhi, May 29

THE DAY the Piprahwa relics landed on the small airstrip in Leh, hundreds of people gathered to catch a glimpse. Once the relics were on their way to Jivetsal, to be displayed for two weeks, Leh saw an unprecedented traffic jam that extended as far as the eye could see.

Tsering Dorjay Lakrook, the president of the Ladakh Buddhist Association, would later say that the arrival of the relics was marked by auspicious signs such as the clearing of clouds over the mountains and the appearance of a rainbow over Spituk Monastery.

This wasn’t the first time the Buddha’s relics had come to the valley, though – they had been brought to Leh for a public exhibition earlier in 1950.

“The war with Pakistan in 1947 had left the Ladakhi community shaken,” Ladakhi scholar and diplomat Sonam Wangchuk Shakspo said. “The

Pakistanis had almost reached Taroo village, around 15-20 km from Leh,” he said.

As the Pakistani forces advanced through Nubra valley, the religious head of Ladakh, the 19th Kushok Bakula Rinpoche, gathered local forces to buttress the Indian Army’s efforts to secure the valley.

According to the Ministry of Defence’s biography of Colonel Chewang Rinchen – the 17-year-old boy who led the Nubra Guards to victory in the war – the local forces played a key role in India’s victory in the 1947-48 war.

According to Shakspo, the Kushok Bakula convinced Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru to send the relics to Ladakh to lift the “spiritual morale” of the local population. The relics were displayed to the public for 79 days in May 1950.

The exhibition is mentioned in Nawang Tsering Shakspo’s book, A Cultural History of Ladakh: “On May 26th, 1950 the relics of two of the main dis-



Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru with the Buddhist leader and India’s future ambassador to Mongolia, the 19th Kushok Bakula Rinpoche, in Leh in 1949. THE NEHRU ARCHIVE

ciples of Lord Buddha were brought to Ladakh. On this occasion Yeshe-don-grup had to give a speech about the significance of the relics to the public. In honour of the celebration of Buddha’s birthday on the 15th of Vaishakhi month he composed poems related to the occasion.”

Scholars and diplomats today view the 1950 Leh exhibition as part of a broader ef-

fort by newly independent India to deploy Buddhist heritage as a form of cultural diplomacy, both in the frontier regions such as Ladakh, and among Buddhist-majority countries across Asia. Over the following decades, relic exhibitions and Buddhist conferences would become an important component of India’s soft power outreach.

According to the Piprahwa

Project, the Buddha relics were first displayed in Sri Lanka in 1978. This was followed by exhibitions in Mongolia in 1993, Singapore in 1994, South Korea in 1995, and Thailand in 1996.

In 2012, at the request of the Sri Lankan President Mahinda Rajapaksa, the relics once again travelled from India to Sri Lanka to commemorate the 2600th anniversary of the Enlightenment of the Buddha. The relics were taken to Sri Lanka by a delegation led by then Minister of Culture Kumari Selja.

The 19th Kushok Bakula felt deeply for the Buddhist communities in Russia and Mongolia. He became the first Buddhist monk to visit these countries, where he advocated for peace and nuclear disarmament.

The Asian Buddhist Conference for Peace (ABCP) was co-established in 1969 by the Bakula Rinpoche along with S Gombojav, the abbot of Gandantegchinlen Monastery in

Ulaanbaatar. The Kushok Bakula shaped the policies and programs of the ABCP as the vice president, and later president, of the organisation.

After the collapse of the Soviet Union, Rinpoche, who was then the Indian ambassador to Mongolia, worked to organise an exhibition of the Buddha’s relics in Ulaanbaatar.

“When the relics arrived in the Mongolian capital, they were treated like state guests,” Shakspo, who worked closely with the Rinpoche during his ambassadorship years in Mongolia, said.

“People lined up outside the exhibition hall from morning to evening. It was a massive success. Thereafter, all Buddhist countries began requesting similar exhibitions – Vietnam, Thailand, Bhutan, and Sri Lanka,” he said.

The author was in Leh during the public exposition of the Sacred Piprahwa Relics of Lord Buddha earlier this month at the invitation of the Ladakh L-G.



Declan Walsh
Mongbwalu, May 30

IN THE cramped, dilapidated Ebola ward, a 5-year-old boy languished on a bare mattress, a tissue stuffed into his nose to stanch the incessant bleeding. His father stood over him, eyes clouded with worry.

A few beds away lay the body of Christiane Bahati, 21, who had died seven hours earlier but had not yet been taken away. Her shoes were still tucked under the bed, her wailing relatives gathered outside the ward doors.

The body, covered by a thin sheet, was highly contagious. Yet hardly anyone in the ward was protected. Relatives came and went, carrying food and

water to ailing patients because the hospital had none to give them. A few wore rubber gloves or pulled a scarf across their mouths. Most had nothing at all.

In the next ward lay the hospital's laboratory technician, also sick. Seven other hospital workers had already died from suspected Ebola.

Few of the staff members had ever been trained to fight the disease, and the most rudimentary equipment was in dangerously short supply: tests, protective suits, goggles, masks, even drinking water.

Outside, the sound of hammering broke the hushed silence. Aid workers from Doctors Without Borders were racing to erect isolation tents and disinfection stations.



Dr Alex Bogole, a Congolese doctor in the hospital's intensive care ward, was furious.

The virus had been spread-

ing for months, virtually unimpeded, "and this is the best we can do?" he said, the frustration pouring through his protective

gear. This is the epicenter of the Ebola outbreak in the Democratic Republic of Congo, and the front line is completely overwhelmed.

The Congolese Health Ministry declared the outbreak on May 15, and it has already ballooned into the third largest on record. Two weeks later, the international response is being outpaced by the virus, and there is almost nothing to slow it down. Aid groups warn that without urgent intervention, this could be the world's deadliest Ebola outbreak ever.

Dr Bogole was never trained for this and was angry at everyone—at the Congolese government for failing to detect the outbreak until perhaps six weeks after it began, and at the

world, which has barely mobilized help here in Mongbwalu, a remote gold mining town of about 150,000 where the outbreak is believed to have started.

"They hold meetings and meetings," he said, struggling to contain his disdain. "What is the purpose of these meetings? People are dying, people are getting infected, people are in danger. It's very slow."

Giant trucks, curling through lush hills, leave blinding clouds of dust. Edgy-looking Congolese soldiers guard checkpoints that are often little more than string.

Gold miners and people fleeing rebel conflict stream in and out of Mongbwalu, providing an excellent vector for the spread of the virus. NYT

RECENT HIKE IN FUEL PRICES MAY ACTIVATE BOTH DIRECT AND INDIRECT TRANSMISSION CHANNELS

Must be vigilant on inflation, may face demand headwinds: Fin Min

The comments come days before the RBI's rate setting panel announces its interest rate decision on June 5

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, May 30

CONSUMPTION DEMAND in India may face headwinds in the coming months with economic conditions beginning to show the impact of the conflict in West Asia, the Ministry of Finance said on Saturday.

It cautioned that while the near-term outlook is one of "cautious resilience", policy will need to "remain agile across monetary, fiscal, and structural dimensions" to tackle the ongoing uncertainty and that inflation developments warrant "vigilance".

"For India, these external pressures are beginning to transmit, selectively but perceptibly, into domestic economic conditions," the finance ministry said in its Monthly Economic Review report for May, adding that the moderation in core sector growth and fuel consumption "signals that global headwinds are gradually finding their way into select segments of domestic activity."

"With forecasts pointing to a below-normal monsoon and a likely moderation in economic activity, overall consumption demand may face headwinds in the coming months," it further said.

It separately said a signifi-

cant rainfall deficit along with the current geopolitical conditions could translate into food inflation, weakening rural demand and aggregate growth.

According to data released on May 20, growth of India's eight core industries — namely coal, crude oil, natural gas, refinery products, fertilisers, steel, cement, and electricity — fell to 1.2% in March and 1.7% in April.

Meanwhile, the India Meteorological Department on Friday cut its monsoon forecast to 90% of the Long Period Average from 92% projected in April. The latest forecast is the lowest by IMD in the last 20 years. The comments by the finance ministry that policy will need to be "agile" and the inflation outlook warrants vigilance come days before the Reserve Bank of India's Monetary Policy Committee announces its interest rate decision on June 5.

After having cut the policy repo rate by 125 basis points (bps) to 5.25% in 2025, the MPC has left it unchanged so far in 2026 amid sharply higher global energy prices due to the war in West Asia, which has led to foreign investors pulling money out from Indian financial markets to the tune of \$24.2 billion since the conflict began in late February.



The finance ministry released its Monthly Economic Review report for May on Saturday. REUTERS

This has exerted tremendous pressure on the Indian rupee's exchange rate, pushing it down to multiple all-time lows. Earlier this month, it nearly breached the 97-per-dollar mark, before it was propped up by sustained RBI intervention in the foreign exchange market.

On Friday, the rupee ended at 95. It has fallen 4.2% since the war started.

While the rupee has recovered some ground in recent days, economists warn that the MPC may have to increase interest rates as early as next week. According to Standard Chartered Bank economists, the RBI may raise the repo rate by 50 bps over its June and August meetings. And they see a risk of additional 25-50 bps of hikes in 2026-27 if inflation turns out to be higher than ex-

pected due to continued pressure from commodity prices and a weak rupee.

In its report on Saturday, the finance ministry took note of the divergence between India's retail and wholesale inflation in April: 3.48% and 8.3%, respectively. This wedge, it said, is a sign that upstream cost pressures are building and the passthrough to consumers may not be far behind. "The recent hike in petrol and diesel prices may activate both direct and indirect transmission channels, and any further escalation in energy prices could narrow the existing cushion more quickly than anticipated. A deficient monsoon could add food price pressures on top of energy-driven ones. However, second-round effects and their persistence must be evident in the

• CHALLENGES AHEAD

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IT SEPARATELY said a significant rainfall deficit along with the current geopolitical conditions could translate into food inflation, weakening rural demand and aggregate growth

data for policy responses to be triggered," the finance ministry said. After holding retail fuel prices at for over two-and-a-half months amid the surge in global rates due to the West Asia crisis, public sector oil marketing companies have raised pump prices of petrol and diesel by over Rs 7 per litre in less than two weeks.

The RBI, in early April, forecast that headline retail inflation as measured by the Consumer Price Index (CPI) may average 4.6% in 2026-27, up from less than 2% in 2025-26. However, economists from outside the central bank see CPI inflation averaging more than 5%. Central banks in Asia have already begun raising interest rates, including Indonesia by 50 bps and Sri Lanka by 100 bps — both in one go — in the last 10 days.

‘Carbon rules, sustainability norms make ESG a compliance priority for industry’

New Delhi: Frameworks such as the EU's carbon tax and the proposed Carbon Credit Trading Scheme by India are rapidly transforming environmental, social and governance (ESG) practices from a voluntary disclosure exercise into a key business and compliance priority for industries, say experts.

Without credible carbon data systems and traceable reporting mechanisms, companies could face increasing compliance risks and competitive disadvantages

in global markets, they said.

"The next phase of ESG will be driven by implementation readiness and data credibility," World of Circular Economy (WOCE) Founder and Director Anup Garg said.

He added that frameworks such as the European Union's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM), India's Business Responsibility and Sustainability Reporting (BRSR) norms and the evolving Carbon Credit Trading Scheme (CCTS)

are rapidly shifting ESG from a voluntary disclosure exercise to a business and compliance priority. While sustainability intent is clearly rising, execution remains uneven, many organisations continue to struggle with structured emission tracking, especially across supply chains and vendor ecosystems, he added.

Citing an analysis, he said that 72% of Indian companies remain at an early stage of carbon readiness despite increasing climate regulations. PTI